



A BARD IS BORN

William was born in this house on Henley Street, Stratford. The house has now been turned into the Birthplace Museum. The rooms have been furnished to show how they would have looked in Shakespeare's time.

Shakespeare's birthplace

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE was born in 1564, in the small town of Stratford-upon-Avon, England. At that time, Stratford had only eight or nine streets and fewer than 1,500 inhabitants. It was a market town, where the local farmers could bring their crops, animals, and other goods to sell. William's exact birth date is not known, but it would have been shortly before his christening, which took place on April 26. He was born into a prosperous middle-class family. His father, John, was one of Stratford's leading men and served on the council that governed the town. He made his living as a glove-maker, and also dealt in wool and timber.



16th-century civic maces

Maces were originally used as weapons

Blue dye came from the woad plant

POSITION OF AUTHORITY

In 1568, John Shakespeare was elected high bailiff of Stratford, which was like being a mayor. His authority was symbolized by an ornamental staff called a mace. This was carried before him in processions by an officer called a sergeant at mace.

LEFTOVERS FOR SALE

Wool was a by-product of glove making. John Shakespeare bought sheepskins from the butchers. He cut away the wool and prepared the skins so that he could use them for his "is gloves. He then sold the wool to Stratford's dyers and weavers. It was dyed using a variety of local plants and woven into cloth.



Yellow dye came from the weld plant, or "dyer's broom"

Red dye came from madder roots



16th-century velvet and satin mittens embroidered with flowers

GLOVE STORY

In the 16th century, wealthy people wore fashionable, beautifully embroidered gloves like these mittens. People also wore gloves for warmth and protection. John Shakespeare may have sold embroidered gloves, but would not have made them himself. Embroidery was done mainly at home by women.

WORK FROM HOME

John Shakespeare's workshop was situated in the house on Henley Street. He prepared the animal skins, then cut and sewed them into gloves. John probably also sold his gloves, wallets, and other leather goods from his workshop.

